Invisible Pioneers: Exploring the Experiences of African American Female Athletes during the Late Civil Rights Era

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Introduction

The experiences of African American women in sport have been largely overlooked by sport sociologists, especially regarding the late Civil Rights Era (Cain, 2000). The current body of research touches on African American women's experiences since the push toward equal sports opportunity for men and women - Title IX. However, the sport experiences of African American women from 1990s to present makes up the majority of the literature.

This raises the overarching question: what were the sports experiences of African American women growing up Pre-Title IX? Given the scarcity of literature and the push for authentic representation (Vertinsky, 1998), this study collects firsthand accounts of six African American women who participated in sport in the Twin Cities in the 1960s and/or 1970s.

These six women have interconnected stories which will enlighten society about the feelings and involvement of women of color in sport. Additionally, researchers will have the opportunity to explore the importance of interpersonal connections between the women and the role sport has played to keep their relationships strong over decades of friendship.

Purpose

The purpose of this project was twofold:

1. To uncover neglected historical information about diverse individuals.
2. To give participants an opportunity to give a public voice to their experiences.

Study findings will not only provide needed historical information, but will also give important feedback for young women of color. This information has potential to be used as inspiration for future generations of African American females, and also to help design physical activity programs based on the experiences of these individuals.

Participants

- Six African American women ages 49 to 64
- All grew up or moved to a major metropolitan area in the Midwest

Measures

- Questions for the focus group were derived from previous literature and observation of a panel participants' conducted.
- A semi-structured interview schedule was developed for individual participants based on responses for the focus group. Pre-determined, open-ended questions were asked of every participant.
- Clarification and elaboration probes were used to help understand the meaning behind participants' responses and reduce personal bias when making interpretations.

Sample Interview Questions:

1. Can you tell me about your sport experiences in high school, college, and after college?
2. Can you talk about the role your family played in your sport participation?
3. In the group interview, you said that, "I'm looking at being an athlete, and being a woman-of-color athlete in [state] is a full time job." What did you mean by that?

Procedure and Analysis

- Obtained appropriate permissions and consent
- Conducted one focus group and interviews with participants at times and locations convenient to participants. The focus group lasted 120 minutes and individual interviews lasted from 45 to 155 minutes.
- Transcribed interviews verbatim and performed inductive content analyses to uncover themes

Preliminary Results

The preliminary results explore the meaning of sport, and why these experiences were valuable, memorable and necessary, to the participants. They also highlight how the roles and relationships of family members, friends and mentors were related to the sport participation of the women. Finally, the preliminary results give voice to the pride the women felt about their experiences.

The first section of the results focuses on themes common to all participants and the second section highlights diverse themes that emerged for individual or a subgroup of participants.

Common Themes Related to Sport Experiences

Relationships	Meaningful	Pride

The following quotes reflect the theme of "Relationships":

"I find that our relationships, they've never faltered, never diminished; we still have them."

"You know, we all played on separate teams, but in reality we are our own team… we can not see each other for years on end and when we come back its like we never missed a step."

"I had to keep explaining to them if it wasn't for them being my teammates I wouldn't be standing on the court by myself *period*."

The following quotes reflect the theme of "Meaningful":

"I honestly don't know what that road would have been because I can't think of anything else that would have provided me with the type of experience and all of the life lessons that sports has…I mean, I know I could probably get it from some of the fine arts, music, speech and debate but I am still not sure it can be delivered as well as it has been delivered through sports."

"We all had a vision that we wanted to continue to help female athletes become successful, not only in basketball but in general in all sports. "

The following quotes reflect the theme of "Pride":

"I actually skated against [name] who won the [year] US Gold medal in the Olympics and beat her two out of three heats but they weren't taking any people of my *hue* into [name] speed skating club and so I didn't get to be a participant."

"When I got drafted during my senior year; it was a dream come true… that was a highlight of my career!"

"The [large event] hosted the table tennis tournament... I was the only person from the parks and rec that was selected to play in the tournament… I got a little trophy, a little medallion, third place! So, I was satisfied. Because playin'… I'll never forget it. It was hard work!"

Diverse Themes Related to Sport Experiences

Necessary	Outlet	Competitive

The following quotes reflect the themes of "Necessary", "Outlet" and "Competitive" respectively:

"You know boys and girls would go down [to community center] and even if you just went down there to watch it for people even honing their own craft or developing playing baseball or softball or basketball you just go down there and feel comfortable."

"Sports was an outlet for me…because of that I exerted a lot of energy and always tried to be the best…my abilities all stem from what I lacked, you know, and didn't have an outlet, so I found sports as an outlet."

"I had to sit in the middle of the court and boycott in order to *play* with the guys…and then when you went out there you better be tough 'cause you're gonna get your teeth knocked out."

Conclusions

- How the women perceived their experiences is important in understanding how their participation was viewed within their historical and cultural context. Through the way these women expressed their pride and enthusiasm within the group and individual interviews, it is clear that participation in sport was an acceptable and valued activity for their community.
- These women bonded through participation in sport and their relationships have endured for decades. This encourages women of today to value their sports experiences for more than the physical activity it provides.
- Future research should continue to explore firsthand accounts of African American female athletes, as it is the first step in collecting authentic historical representation.

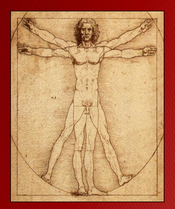
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